



pawning his wife's jewellery to finance the film. It was only later that the West Bengal Government stepped in to finance the film as a documentary on road improvement, as the title had the word 'path' in it and the story took place in a rural setting. The state government is still the producer of the film and holds its copyright.

This doesn't make a difference to Sankranti Creations. Rajeev Dwivedi, who heads the company that also added colour to the not-so-well-done *Naya Daur*, and the better-finished and successful *Mughal-e-Azam*, says he has requested an NOC from the state government just to give them their due. Believing a colour film creates its own copyright, he has already shown a demo tape of the coloured version to the state Culture Ministry, which is headed by Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya. He says talks are in progress to design a revenue-sharing deal, but nothing is final yet. Compared to the Rs 3 crore that was put into colouring *Mughal-e-Azam* in 2004, a film like *Pathar Panchali* would cost a



POETRY IN MOTION: Scenes from *Pathar Panchali* (anti-clockwise from top left) Apu's aunt; his mother Sarbojaya with the aunt; a coloured still (done by INDIA TODAY) of Apu's sister Durga and his aunt

APU'S PATH TO SUCCESS

Financed by Ray, his friends, Balai Mukherjee, Bula Mahalonobis, Kishore Kumar, and the state government

Cost Less than Rs 1 lakh

**Total box office revenue
Rs 12 lakh till 1959**

Colouring cost Rs 65 lakh

little over Rs 1 crore. With touching up of music costing Rs 25-30 lakh and about Rs 35 lakh for publicity and marketing, the actual colouring cost would be only Rs 65 lakh. Bengali distributors are already eager to take up the film and Dwivedi feels it will attract young audiences. "Even if it doesn't do well in theatres, satellite rights, DVD sales, and the international market will bring in profits," he says. He claims Sankranti Creations is not distorting the film.

Reproducing old films in colour has become a new fad in the idea-starved Bollywood. Another reason is the easy and cheap technology involved—from converting the film into digital format, restoring, painstakingly colouring, to reconverting to film. Sankranti Creations will soon be colouring Chetan Anand's *Haqeeqat* (1964) and is also speaking to Dev Anand to work on his *Hum Dono* (1961).

Dwivedi plans to release the film in December, if all goes well. For De it will be nothing less than "a distortion of cinematic history by killing a poem on celluloid." ■